

Teagasc AI Policy

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1. Background

The European Union AI Act (2024) introduces a comprehensive regulatory framework for the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) within the EU. In line with this and Ireland's National AI Strategy Refresh 2024, Teagasc recognises the potential of AI to enhance agricultural research, advisory services, education, and administration. This policy ensures that the use of AI at Teagasc is ethical, transparent, safe, and compliant with all applicable laws and standards (such as EU and Irish government, see section 7).

2. Purpose of the Policy

To establish a clear framework for the development, deployment, and use of AI within Teagasc. The policy defines responsibilities, compliance requirements, and governance structures to ensure trustworthy AI practices.

3. Applicability

This policy applies to all Teagasc staff, to persons working on a contract basis for Teagasc, to all students, seconded staff and external contractors and all other users who access the Teagasc network resources or who are connected to the Teagasc network at any location. It also covers remote Teagasc users who work with Teagasc supplied computers.

4. Policy Statement

Teagasc is committed to using AI responsibly, following a risk-based approach aligned with the EU AI Act. All AI systems will be classified, registered, reviewed, and governed based on their risk level. AI use must uphold principles of transparency, accountability, privacy, fairness, and sustainability.

I. Core AI Principles:

Teagasc aligns its AI policy with the seven AI Principles as outlined in the 'Guidelines for the Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence in the Public Service', which can be summarised as:

- 1. Human Agency and Oversight** – People must remain in control.
- 2. Technical Robustness and Safety** – AI systems must be reliable and secure.
- 3. Privacy and Data Governance** – AI use must uphold data protection laws.
- 4. Transparency** – Use of AI must be clear, visible, and explainable.

5. **Diversity, Non-Discrimination, and Fairness** – AI should promote inclusion and prevent unfair bias.
6. **Societal and Environmental Well-being** – AI should contribute positively to sustainability and society.
7. **Accountability** – Clear lines of responsibility must be maintained across the AI lifecycle.

II. **Acceptable Use.**

Teagasc permits the use of generative AI tools, in appropriate circumstances. Teagasc will not engage in the development or implementation of high risk AI models, as defined by the EU AI act.

AI offer many benefits in the research, advisory, education and administration spheres, but their use also raises concerns. Users need to be aware of the following in evaluating whether their use is appropriate, and how best to use them:

- **Accuracy:** Always validate AI-generated content due to risk of error.
- **Transparency:** Users must disclose substantial AI usage and cite appropriately.
- **Explainability:** Decisions influenced by AI must be justifiable—especially under GDPR.
- **Data Privacy:** No personal data should be supplied unless GDPR compliant.
- **Bias Awareness:** Recognize and mitigate training data biases.
- **IP & Legal Risks:** AI outputs may raise copyright, patent, or liability concerns.
- **Ethical Boundaries:** Tools must not violate legal or institutional ethical standards.
- **Training & Awareness:** Staff must stay informed on AI developments and risks.
- **Accountability:** Final decisions remain the user's responsibility.
- **Ongoing Monitoring:** AI systems must be continuously evaluated for performance.
- **Third-Party Integrity:** AI must not conflict with partners' quality assurance rules.

III. **AI Oversight Group**

Teagasc shall establish an *AI Ethics and Compliance committee* reporting to the ICT Committee. Responsibilities include:

- Reviewing and advising on high-impact AI projects
- Reviewing high-risk applications
- Define technical and ethical standards for AI use

IV. **AI Project Registration**

All internal AI developed models must be added to the Teagasc AI register and be subject to:

- Risk Assessment
- Ethics Review
- Security Review
- Impact Assessment (where applicable)

V. **Data & Privacy**

- AI systems must only use data lawfully acquired and managed per Teagasc's Data Protection Policy.
- External AI models used must not transmit Teagasc data to third-party platforms without explicit consent.

VI. **Procurement & Third-Party AI**

When procuring AI-enabled tools or services:

- Vendors must demonstrate compliance with EU AI Act (if applicable).
- Contracts must include clauses on data handling, accountability, and ongoing support

VII. **Skills & Training**

Teagasc shall provide training in AI literacy for all Teagasc ICT system users.

VIII. **AI in Public Engagement**

Public-facing AI:

- Must clearly disclose AI involvement
- Must be designed to inform and educate in a safe and transparent manner

5. Enforcement

Breaches of this policy by any user may lead to the withdrawal of the ICT services and may result in HR disciplinary procedures being invoked, under the [Teagasc Investigatory & Disciplinary Code](#). Any Third Party service provider found to have violated this policy may result in the withdrawal of Teagasc ICT resources and/or the cancellation of any contract(s) between Teagasc and the Third Party service provider.

Non-compliance may also be reported to the Data Protection Officer

6. Definitions and Terms

AI Model / System: A machine-based system that makes predictions.. or decisions using algorithms or data analysis.

High-Impact AI: Systems designated as high-risk under the EU AI Act.

AI Register: A central record of all AI systems in use within Teagasc, including their classification, risk assessments, and oversight status.

AI-Generated Content

Content that is wholly or predominantly created by an AI system, with minimal human editing or oversight. Examples include full draft reports, summaries, visualisations, or responses generated without significant human intervention.

AI-Assisted Content

Content where AI tools have contributed in a supportive or supplementary role, such as suggesting

edits, analysing data, translating text, generating outlines, or providing input that is substantially revised or validated by a human author.

7. Related Documents

[Security & Usage Policies](#)

- [Teagasc Acceptable Use Policy](#)
- [Teagasc Data Protection Policy](#)
- [EU Artificial Intelligence Act \(2024\)](#)
- [Guidelines for the Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence in the Public Service](#)

8. Revision History

Revision date	Version	Summary of Changes
08-04-2025	0.1	Initial draft
06-05-2025	0.2	Updates
07-07-2025	0.3	Updates to reflect new Governemnt Public Sector Guidelines
10-07-2025	0.4	Updates from Ethics & Compliance committee
16-07-2025	1.0	Updates ICT committee

Note: The referenced AI Ethics & Compliance Committee does not serve as a formal research ethics body and will defer to the Research Ethics Committee for all matters relating to research involving human subjects, academic integrity, or formal academic review.